

Interviewer: Hi, thank you for agreeing to participate in our research!

Speaker: Yeah, but you know 'di ba? I'm very nervous about the recording.

Interviewer: Yes, don't worry, as promised, this will remain confidential and as per your request awhile ago, I won't upload this recording in our drive.

Speaker: Argh, okay, I think I really need to share also kasi I'm stressed, you know naman diba.

Interviewer: Hehe okay, I'm just going to follow our interview guide for our interview. I'm going to read the int[Partner's Name]uction part first for uniformity across our interviews. So, thank you again for participating in this interview. As I've mentioned, we want to know more about your views on romantic relationships and we believe your experience and perspective would bring much to the project. Before we begin, is it alright if we record this interview? We will only use it for transcription/note taking.

Interviewer: How old are you?

Speaker: I'm [50-55] na. God, I'm so old na.

Interviewer: How long have you been together with your partner?

Speaker: We've been together for [20-25] years now. I was so young pa when we met!

Interviewer: Do you have children?

Speaker: We have [1-5] adopted children. [Name] and [Name]. They are [1-5] years apart.

Interviewer: Who lives in the household?

Speaker: So it's me and [Partner's Name] and the [1-5] kids. We have [1-5] [household members] but we rent an [location] for them outside so they also have their privacy. Tapos mother and daughter itong househelp namin and the daughter sleeps here para at night when the kids need something she's there to help.

Interviewer: How would you like us to address your partner?

Speaker: You can call him [Partner's Name]. I call him [Nickname] or [Nickname] most of the time since we had the kids, before we called each other [endearment] but now we are parents, so...

Interviewer: Can you tell me about your love story?

Speaker: My God, I was so young back then, like a teenager pa. So I was an incoming [year] sa [University] and I stayed with my friend. Kasi I am from [City], my family lives there and I have no one here in [City]. She and [Partner's Name] lived in the same village so we used to hangout.

Speaker: Tapos ako naman crush ko siya kasi he's so handsome tapos parang he used to be a [occupation] pa, ako naman super impressed as a probinsyana. I was so kilig with the attention but I was so nene pa back then.

Speaker: So then eventually I found out that he also has a crush on me. We went on a few dates but I didn't really think that it was gonna work, parang it's more of a summer fling. I remember when I had to go to [University], he'd accompany me, I remember nga he told me pa na when we're crossing the roads parang it's required to hold hands, or something like that so we held hands whenever we'd cross the street. O 'di ba, para paraan pa before.

Interviewer: Oo nga po!

Speaker: Yeah, 'di ba ako naman uto-uto pa so, ayun and also I wanted to hold hands din so ayun! Then, I came back to [City], nothing really happened during that summer, I lived my life in [City] but you know I remember my mom told asked me if I'd be willing to go to college in [Country], parang she said she could arrange something for me, kasi we also had relatives there, but then I said parang I want to go to college here in [City], kasi din siyempre probinsyana ako 'diba, so the idea of going to [City] is exciting for me. Tapos lahat ng friends ko halos [City] ang punta, so I feel like I'd be left out. I think my mom was disappointed nga during that time eh kasi diba sayang ang opportunity, going back nga parang sayang!

Speaker: Then ayun college time, [Partner's Name] and I parang we were always part of each other's lives kasi nga we have the same social circle, pero I had boyfriends and he also had many girlfriends but we never really rekindled anything sooner after that summer thing. Then eventually, I graduated and worked as [occupation] for [6-10] years, tapos nagkaroon ako noon ng long term boyfriend, he was a [occupation]. Parang that's one of my serious relationships talaga before [Partner's Name]. [Partner's Name] and I we're more like friends who became lovers. After that serious relationship that I've had, meron pa akong ibang mga naging boyfriends tapos [Partner's Name] was like my guy best friend and I was his girl best friend we tell each other about our relationship problems then one time with our friends they joked us na parang bakit hindi nalang kayo, kasi we were sort of holding hands under the table.

Interviewer: Did your ka-relationships at the time get jealous of him or did any of his girlfriends get jealous of you?

Speaker: Not that I know of! But some of my boyfriends know him also or got to meet him once or twice, pero we became more like friends talaga after that summer thing when we were younger. But as friends more of when we were adults and were hanging out with our mutual friends. I was also busy as a [occupation], I was based in [Country] before, we rekindled our friendship when I got back home and resigned from work eh. Then after nga noong incident

when we were teased, our friends said, you are both single now, why don't you guys try naman? So we did, ayun nga lang parang nabigla siya kasi I had my expectations na, na how I was with my boyfriends that how I was with him. Akala niya siguro I'd be chill as a friend pa din, pero iba kasi when you are in a relationship, parang you are accountable to each other diba. So nag-break pa kami n'on. Tapos we got back together after we both attended a friend's wedding, sabi pa nga ng mga [relative] and friends ko na huwag daw akong bibigay kaagad, parang act like you are not interested. Pero after, siyempre, we got tot talking and then agreed na we're going to try again naman. Kasi to be honest when we broke up I thought na we'd get back together eh, na we're going to try pa kasi we never really tried then.

Speaker: Then eventually many things happened, then he proposed to me sa [Segment], I said yes, and here we are today, although I don't know how long we'll last pa, you know naman!

Interviewer: Hehe, oo nga po you told me some of your challenges a few days ago. How would you compare the quality of your relationship compared to that of your friends' relationship?

Speaker: You mean to our friends?

Interviewer: Yes po.

Speaker: I mean, I'm not that sure kasi I don't really ask about my friends' marriages eh. That's the thing with me kasi over the years with my anxiety and all, I've learned to be more private, parang that's one of my challenges also with [Partner's Name], kasi him, he likes to Marites, parang he has tons of group chats and he really entertains in all of those group chats. So he knows more of what's happening to other people. I'm only mostly aware of the marriage of my former best friend, pero her naman her husband also couldn't tolerate her so I think we're just both in a slump. Slump marriages if you may call it. I'm sure all couples are having challenges but we lasted for [20-25] years but I couldn't really say we're doing so much better than others. Kasi nga for now di ba I kicked him out of the house because of what he did. Can you imagine? He was ratting me out to my best friend. He was upset with me for always wanting him home tapos he didn't respect my friendship with [Name].

Interviewer: Can you tell me what happened?

Speaker: [redacted]

Speaker: Hay, to answer your question siguro, maybe compared to our other friends, baka mas malala kami. I just don't know what they're going through pero baka hindi naman kasing lala nito.

Interviewer: You seem very upset with what happened. If I may ask the next question, can I also ask how many romantic partners you've had in the past and how would you compare the quality of your relationship to your previous relationships?

Speaker: Funny question! Serious relationships, I had [1-5]. Pero yung last boyfriend ko before si [Partner's Name], ayun yung super serious talaga na we could've really gotten married, pero he was a womanizer. Parang he's an [nationality] kasi. Pero if I'm going to compare my relationship, ano ba, kasi right now I'm so upset with [Partner's Name] that I'm having a hard time seeing the good things in him so mababa talaga ang rating ko ngayon sa marriage namin. Pero as a relationship in general? Let's see the [Nationality] kasi we're so different from them. Like I noticed [Nationality] dudes, [Nationality] guys, they don't really expect to be taken cared of, hindi kagaya ng mga [Nationality] parang they expect you to baby them, prepare meals for them, things like that. I think in terms of preference ng independence I'd rate my previous relationship better. Pero [Partner's Name] naman can be sweet at times siguro in terms of making you feel pampered, he's better at that naman. Pero I think I cannot really gauge, kasi when you're married, you're married eh, you tend to behave differently unlike if you're just boyfriend and girlfriend parang honeymoon period pa yan. Iba talaga kapag kasal kayo, merong commitment, you are a team. So I cannot say din na entirely lower quality our marriage, kasi we also have actively decided to stay. We have contemplated about separating many times na, pero every time, we decide to stay. I don't know if that's good or bad pero it's something 'di ba? To choose to stay, ayon, with his offense to me, I am in a position where I don't know if I want to stay or not kasi honestly I'm also tired of everything, the kids also. I don't really have time for myself anymore.

Interviewer: So speaking of your needs also, for you what are the most important things in a relationship?

Speaker: In a relationship, there has to be respect talaga teacher, kasi if you don't respect each other wala na. Like for me, I really need my personal time, I need my peace, my me time. I have sleeping problems so peace and quiet lang naman talaga ang hinihingi ko. I should also feel that we are the priority, kasi sometimes si [Partner's Name] he feels like he's still single, maybe because we were childfree for so long. Kasi our children are adopted eh tapos their ages are so young pa, they are [6-10] and [6-10] year olds eh. [redacted].

Speaker: Yes I do have anxiety but it's from different traumas of my life. [redacted]. So nasaan na nga tayo? Sorry I think I got off topic.

Interviewer: No, it's okay po. I was asking about the most important thing in a relationship, you mentioned that it is respect and personal time for you and then you talked about having anxiety. I think the context is that you feel like sometimes [Partner's Name] is at times, acting like he's single and that you wanted that he make you feel that family is really his priority?

Speaker: Yes, yes! Ayun na nga, so I think those are the things that are important in a relationship. A couple should respect each other and be on the same page especially if you're raising kids. I think a challenge for us din dahil we adopted late. We are in our [50-55] na eh. We weren't thinking about adopting sana, actually our first kid, [Name], he's a foundling, parang a friend asked us if we'd be willing to open our doors to a child kasi may batang iniwan sakanya. At first I said no kasi nga we both decided to be child free a long time ago and we weren't ready.

Pero that night, di ako makatulog, parang I thought I'm such a hypocrite if I don't open our doors for this boy, we have an extra room, and I'm also adopted myself. So I was thinking, paano kung ako yon. Someone took me in so we called that person again and then [Partner's Name] and I went to the mall and bought mga baby stuff all in one day! Then we figured that being adopted is difficult so we adopted another child, [Name], our girl, para sana they could be in this process together. So with all of our challenges tapos his activities, sometimes I don't feel like we are his priority or parang ako lang with the kids.

Interviewer: Oh, okay, kaya po pala you feel stressed, maybe the age is a huge factor din po noh? Parang taking care of kids at [50-55]-years-old. Now, I just want to ask a cliché question, what is love for you?

Speaker: Hay, love, ano nga ba? Hmmm, let me think... at this age, our love is there but it's more quiet kase. It's not the love that you experience when you are young na you feel so attracted to the person but it's more of the togetherness. I think love for us, is staying despite what we are going through. It's our decision to stay despite the challenges and the fights. You don't know how many times we've talked about separating but we're still here trying to make it work. But with what he did, I don't know if we'll ever be you know as we were before this happened, I felt so betrayed kasi. In his defense he said he wanted an unbiased opinion of how we were doing pero he didn't anticipate that my friend will encourage him to separate with me. I also didn't anticipate that. I think if ever we'll separate, we'll still be part of each other's lives, 'di na maiiba yun. The love will always be there pero mins

Speaker:an baka you have to leave na.

Interviewer: You really seem upset with what happened recently and I can understand why. Hmm, may I also ask how do you know your partner loves you?

Well, here's the thing eh. You know the person loves you but there are times that you don't feel it. Maybe I can feel that he loves me whenever he makes me feel that we are his priority at hindi yung mga friends niya. Sometimes kasi I feel trapped, I couldn't do the things that I used to do before we adopted. Between the two of us, he was the one who really wanted to adopt a long long time ago, now that the kids are here, I mean, don't get me wrong ha, I love them but there are moments that I feel like I don't have freedom anymore because I spend too much of my time taking care of them, [Partner's Name] and the kids.